Nalanda University was the Harvard, Oxbridge, Nasa of its day. It was the very first plan of a university quad, the kind you see in Oxford or Cambridge today

Everyone in America, Britain, Africa, Australia, Canada can tell you about Archimedes and Pythagoras, but no one outside India knows about Aryabhatta or Brahmagupta, mathematicians of absolutely equal stature who shepherded the number system that the whole world uses in just nine figures plus zero



WILLIAM DALRYMPLE
Author

INDIA'S ANCIENT SOFT POWER

THE GOLDEN BIRD

The most anticipated session of the India Today Conclave, William Dalrymple did not disappoint. Armed with anecdote, historical evidence, maps, ancient and modern, and numerous slides, the author of *The Golden Road* held his audience enthralled, as he set out to "situate India's rise in its historical context because history shows very clearly that for most of history, India has been the richest region of the world". Debunking the idea of the Silk Road as some sort of "geopolitical trade route", Dalrymple argued it was India that was the principal trading partner of the Roman Empire and every year, fleets of hundreds of vessels left the Egyptian coast, went down the Red Sea, and arrived in India, not China. The Silk Road, in his view, prospered from Chinese propaganda.

On the influence of India's knowledge systems on China, Dalrymple pointed to the fact of Buddhism rising to be China's state religion for a while despite its Indian origin. "Indians are not fully aware of the influence of Buddhism and Indian thought on China. Today, China and India are often made up to be rival poles of influence. But there was never any Chinese religion which came and took over India," he added.

"If you look at the map of the influence of Buddhism, you have its origins in places like Lumbini, Bodhgaya and Sarnath.... Within 200-300 years, it spreads to Gandhara and Central Asia, reaching China, Mongolia, Korea and Japan. It moves down to Vietnam, Laos, Thailand, Cambodia and the Philippines. This was the golden age of Indian soft power," he explained.

It wasn't just religious and philosophical ideas but also Indian languages and scripts that spread. In Fact, Dalrymple said, every single script in Southeast Asia today is an evolution out of the Pallava script. "Which is why, if you are a Tamil or a Malayalam speaker, you can actually read the beginnings of Thai and Mon and Khmer," he noted. ■

To watch the full session, visit https://bitly.cx/AFfU